False friends packet

Words that look like English but mean something else — 200 false friends from the Common Mistakes tool, in both directions. Print this packet and work on paper.

Name: _____ Date: _____

A **false friend** is a Spanish word that *looks* like an English word but means something different. *Embarazada* looks like “embarrassed” but means *pregnant*. *Éxito* looks like “exit” but means *success*. Guessing from the English lookalike is exactly the trap — so this packet makes you face the trap head-on: every item gives you the real meaning and the lookalike side by side, and you must pick the real one. It works in both directions, Spanish to English and English to Spanish, because the trap works both ways. Learn each word’s real meaning by heart; there is no shortcut around it.

1. Match the real meaning

Write the letter of the real English meaning next to each Spanish word. Do not pick the lookalike — pick what the word really means.

1. embarazada
2. éxito
3. librería
4. largo
5. actualmente
6. asistir
7. recordar
8. pretender
9. soportar
10. molestar
11. realizar
12. colegio

a. school
b. to carry out
c. to bother
d. to put up with
e. to try
f. to remember
g. to attend
h. currently
i. long
j. bookstore
k. success
l. pregnant

2. The trap — Spanish to English

Each Spanish word looks like an English word. That English lookalike is the trap. Circle the **real** meaning, not the lookalike.

1. **lectura** — Me gusta la lectura.: (reading / lecture)
2. **sensible** — Es muy sensible al frío.: (sensible / sensitive)
3. **constipado** — Estoy constipado y toso mucho.: (having a cold / constipated)
4. **carpeta** — Guarda los papeles en la carpeta.: (carpet / folder)
5. **actual** — El mes actual es noviembre.: (current / actual)
6. **advertir** — Te advierto del peligro.: (to advertise / to warn)
7. **balón** — El balón es de fútbol.: (ball / balloon)

8. **campo** — El campo es verde.: (camp / countryside)
9. **casualidad** — Fue una casualidad, no un plan.: (coincidence / casualty)
10. **conductor** — El conductor maneja el autobús.: (conductor / driver)
11. **contestar** — Contesta la pregunta, por favor.: (to answer / to contest)
12. **decepción** — Qué decepción, no ganó el premio.: (deception / disappointment)

3. Write the real meaning — Spanish to English

Write the real English meaning of each Spanish word. The sentence shows the word in use; the English lookalike is not the answer.

1. **desgracia** — Qué desgracia, se rompió la pierna.: _____
2. **tarjeta** — La tarjeta es azul.: _____
3. **fábrica** — Trabaja en una fábrica de zapatos.: _____
4. **firma** — Escribe tu firma aquí.: _____
5. **globo** — El globo flota en el aire.: _____
6. **introducir** — Introduce la llave en la cerradura.: _____
7. **noticia** — Veo las noticias cada noche.: _____
8. **pan** — Como pan todos los días.: _____
9. **pariente** — Es pariente lejano.: _____
10. **profesión** — ¿Cuál es tu profesión?: _____
11. **quitar** — Quita la mesa, por favor.: _____
12. **receta** — Sigue la receta para hacer el pan.: _____

4. Match the real meaning — English to Spanish

Write the letter of the real Spanish meaning next to each English word. The Spanish lookalike is the trap.

1. embarrassed	a. universidad
2. exit	b. darse cuenta
3. library	c. mil millones
4. large	d. apoyar
5. actually	e. fingir
6. assist	f. grabar
7. record	g. ayudar
8. pretend	h. en realidad
9. support	i. grande
10. billion	j. biblioteca
11. realize	k. salida
12. college	l. avergonzada

5. The trap — English to Spanish

Each English word looks like a Spanish word. That Spanish lookalike is the trap. Circle the **real** Spanish meaning, not the lookalike.

1. **lecture** — The lecture was very long.: (conferencia / lectura)
2. **sensible** — That was a sensible decision.: (sensible / sensato)
3. **constipated** — He is constipated and needs medicine.: (estreñido / constipado)
4. **carpet** — The carpet is red.: (carpeta / alfombra)
5. **actual** — The actual price is higher.: (real / actual)
6. **advertise** — They advertise the new phone on TV.: (advertir / anunciar)
7. **balloon** — The balloon floats in the air.: (globo / balón)
8. **camp** — We camp in the mountains.: (campo / acampar)
9. **casualty** — There was one casualty in the accident.: (víctima / casualidad)
10. **conductor** — Copper is a good conductor.: (conductor / material conductor)
11. **contest** — He will contest the decision.: (impugnar / contestar)
12. **deception** — The deception was discovered.: (decepción / engaño)

6. Write the real meaning — English to Spanish

Write the real Spanish meaning of each English word. The sentence shows the word in use; the Spanish lookalike is not the answer.

1. **disgrace** — It was a disgrace to lose like that.: _____
2. **target** — Hit the target in the center.: _____
3. **fabric** — This shirt is made of soft fabric.: _____
4. **firm** — She works for a big firm.: _____
5. **globe** — The globe shows the whole world.: _____
6. **introduce** — Let me introduce my friend Ana.: _____
7. **notice** — Did you see the notice on the door?: _____
8. **pan** — Cook the eggs in the pan.: _____
9. **parent** — My parent is a teacher.: _____
10. **professor** — The professor teaches history.: _____
11. **quit** — He decided to quit his job.: _____
12. **receipt** — Keep the receipt for the shoes.: _____

7. Use them in sentences

Write one Spanish sentence for each word below, using the word with its **real** meaning.

1. Use **red** in a Spanish sentence.

2. Use **ropa** in a Spanish sentence.

3. Use **sano** in a Spanish sentence.

4. Use **simpático** in a Spanish sentence.

5. Use **suceso** in a Spanish sentence.

6. Use **vaso** in a Spanish sentence.

8. Review quiz

Ten quick items, mixed in both directions. Circle the real meaning — never the lookalike.

1. **taller** — El taller está cerrado.: (workshop / taller)
2. **bizarro** — Es bizarro en la batalla.: (bizarre / brave)
3. **suceder** — ¿Qué sucedió ayer?: (to happen / to succeed)
4. **reunión** — La reunión de trabajo es a las tres.: (reunion / meeting)
5. **retirar** — Retiró el dinero del banco.: (to withdraw / to retire)
6. **red** — The car is red.: (red / rojo)
7. **rope** — Tie the rope to the tree.: (cuerda / ropa)
8. **sane** — He is sane and calm.: (sano / cuerdo)
9. **sympathetic** — She was sympathetic and listened.: (compasiva / simpático)
10. **success** — The party was a success.: (suceso / éxito)

9. Reflection

Answer in English or Spanish.

1. Which false friend in this packet surprised you most? Why did you expect it to mean something else?

2. Write three Spanish sentences, each using a different false friend from this packet with its real meaning.

3. Think of an English word you know that looks like a Spanish word. How would you check whether it is a false friend or a true cognate?

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_____

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Answer key (teachers): packet-false-friends-answers.pdf